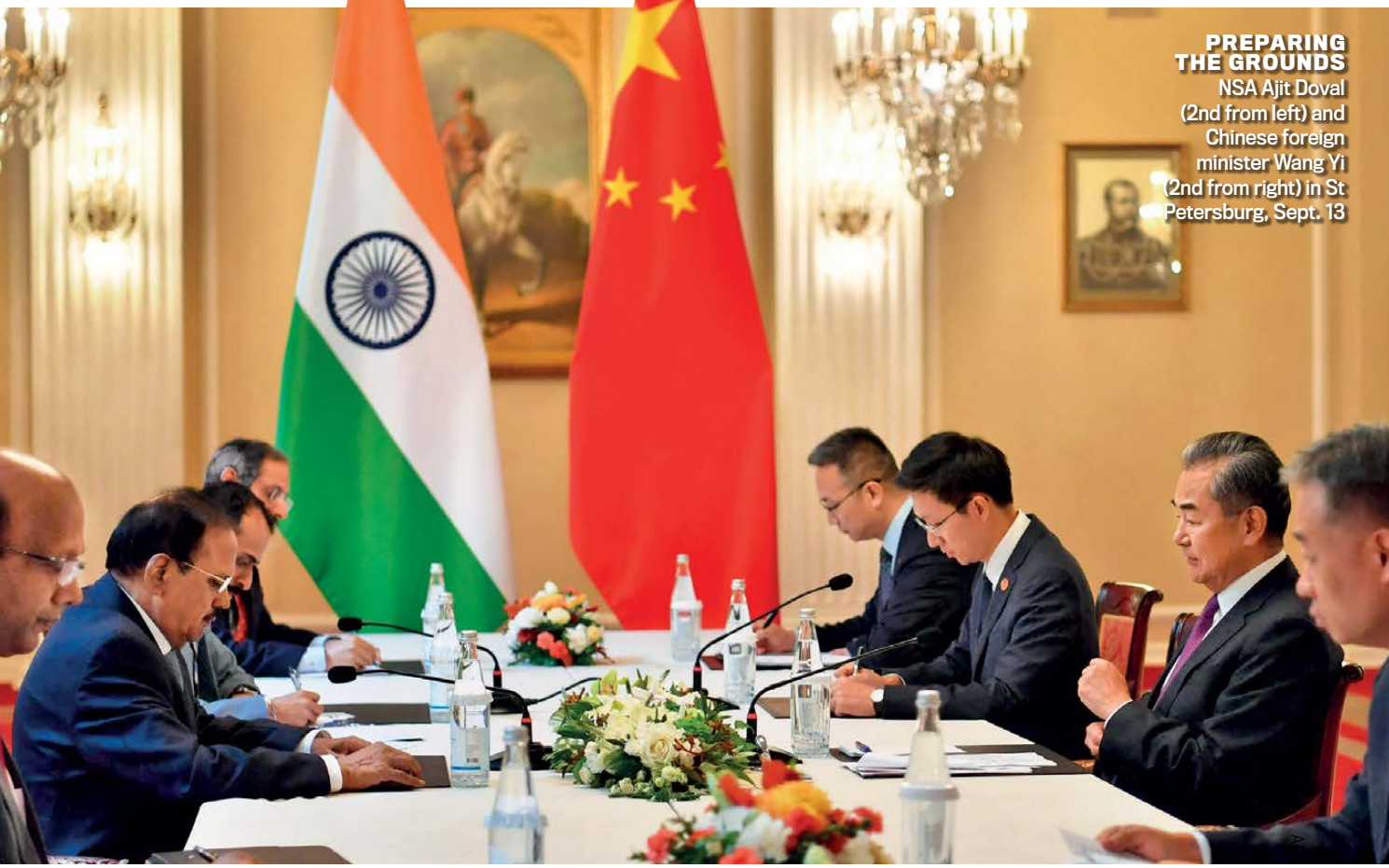
UTTAR PRADESH: BYPOLL JOUST PG 11

ANDHRA PRADESH: FLOOD OF NEGLECT PG 13

W. BENGAL: MEDICS WIN FIRST ROUND PG 12

JHARKHAND: BATTLELINES DRAWN PG 15



PREPARING THE GROUNDS
NSA Ajit Doval (2nd from left) and Chinese foreign minister Wang Yi (2nd from right) in St Petersburg, Sept. 13

AFP

INDIA-CHINA

SIGNS OF A THAW

By Pradip R. Sagar

After two years of frozen relations between India and China, there seems to be indications of a defrost. On September 13, when National Security Advisor Ajit Doval met Chinese foreign minister Wang Yi on the sidelines of a BRICS (Brazil-Russia-India-China-South Africa) meeting in St Petersburg, Russia, both sides agreed to expedite "complete disengagement" on the remaining friction points along the border, where Chinese and Indian armies have been engaged in a protracted stand-off since May 2020. On the same day, highlighting progress in India-China talks, external affairs minister S. Jaishankar acknowledged that "75 per cent" of the "disengagement problems" have been resolved. Some see the use of the term "complete disengagement" as significant in that the stage is being set for a resumption of high-level political dialogue between the two nations, as military and diplomatic talks seem to have reached their limit. It's now up to the top political leadership to push the issue towards a satisfactory resolution, they say. Overall, the hopeful messaging from Wang, Doval and Jaishankar is seen as preparatory to three potentially key diplomatic moments—a meeting at